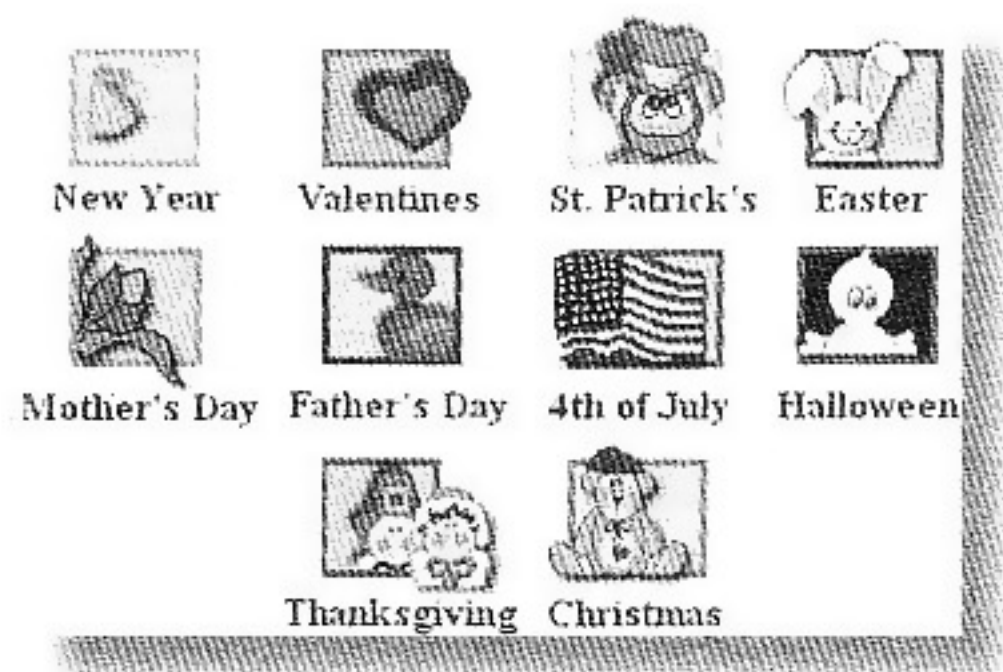


24 PUBLIC HOLIDAYS



I will honour Christmas in my heart, and try to keep it all the year.

Scrooge from Christmas Carol by Charles Dickens

A New Year's resolution is something that goes in one Year and out the other.

Unknown

□ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **public holidays:** bank holidays (in Britain)

- **CHRISTIAN HOLIDAYS:**

- Christmas**

- commemorates the birth of Jesus
 - *Christmas Eve* (December 24th), *Christmas Day* (December 25th), *Boxing Day* (December 26th)
 - Christmas decorations (lights, advent calendars, Christmas tree, Father Christmas, Santa Claus, reindeer, angels, devils, mistletoe, ivy, holly, candles, bells, wreath)
 - Christmas habits (fasting, going to church, carolling, giving presents, having festive dinner)

- Easter**

- celebrates the resurrection of Jesus
 - *Shrove Tuesday*, *Ash Wednesday*, *Clean Monday*, *Lent*, *Great Lent*, *Palm Sunday*, *Holy Week*, *Maundy Thursday*, *Good Friday*, *Holy Saturday*, *Easter Sunday*, *Whit Monday*
 - pancakes, hot cross buns, Easter eggs, Easter Bunnies
 - in Slovakia: willow whips, chasing girls and pouring water on them
 - “*Fašiangy*” (in Slovakia)
 - the burial of the contrabass, typical cakes, such as “*fánky*”, “*šišky*”

- **SAINTS' HOLIDAYS:**

- St. Valentine's Day*
 - St. Patrick's Day*
 - St. Andrew's Day*
 - St. David's Day*
 - St. George's Day*
 - All Saints' Day*

- **PATRIOTIC HOLIDAYS:**

- in the USA: *Memorial Day*, *Veteran's Day*, *President's Day*, *Columbus Day*, *Thanksgiving Day*, Pilgrim Fathers (17th century), the Mayflower ship, famine, survival, successful harvest, turkey
 - Fourth of July or *Independence Day*: signing of the Declaration of Independence in the 18th century
 - in Britain: *Guy Fawkes Night*: historical background in 17th century, Guy Fawkes, bonfires, fireworks, rockets

- **OTHER HOLIDAYS:**

- Halloween:** carved pumpkins, candles, witches, goblins, ghosts, cemetery, skeleton, fancy dress costumes, trick-or-treat, sweets, toffee apples (in Britain), candy apples (in the USA)

□ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. Why are public holidays in Britain called "bank holidays"?
2. What do you know about holidays celebrated in Great Britain?
3. What do you know about holidays celebrated in the USA?
4. Why is the 4th of July such an important holiday for Americans?
5. Which holidays do you celebrate in your country?
6. Do you think Halloween should be celebrated in your country?
7. What is traditionally eaten in your country at Christmas?
8. In which ways are Christmas traditions different in Slovakia, Britain and the USA?
9. Which public holidays do you like most? Why?
10. Which holidays celebrated in your country do you find special and unique? Why?

□ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold and answer the questions below.

Public holidays in Great Britain are called "bank holidays". Traditionally, all banks, offices, schools, shops and factories are closed on these days, although it is becoming more common for supermarkets to **remain** open. Bank holidays include the following days: *New Year's Day*, **Good Friday** and **Easter Monday** (Easter holidays), *Whit Monday* (seven weeks after Easter), *August Bank Holiday* (the last Monday in August), *Christmas Day* (December 25th) and *Boxing Day* (December 26th).

CHRISTIAN HOLIDAYS

CHRISTMAS

Christmas is the most beautiful religious holiday. Special Christmas decorations, advent calendars, bells, angels, coloured lights and Christmas trees can be seen in the streets and shops. Homes are often decorated long before Christmas with **holly**, **ivy** or **mistletoe**. **Christmas carols** are sung almost everywhere, in houses, cathedrals and churches. People buy presents and send Christmas cards and text messages to their relatives and friends. For Christians, Christmas is much more connected with going to church to **holly masses**, praying to Jesus Christ, **fasting**, helping people in need through **good acts**, charities or Christmas benefit concerts. In Slovakia, Christmas preparations are connected with cleaning households, baking **gingerbread** and other pastries, decorating houses with lights and visiting **Christmas markets** where **spirits**, such as hot "medovina" (mead in English), **mulled wine** (hot wine) or Christmas punch, are sold. On December 24th (*Christmas Eve*), Slovak people have a festive dinner which is followed by the **unwrapping** of presents found under the Christmas tree. The Christmas menu in Slovakia **varies** from region to region: **wafers** with garlic, honey and black pepper are followed either by lentil soup, "halászle" (Hungarian fish soup), mush-

room soup or sauerkraut soup; for the second course it is fish (usually **carp**) with a mayonnaise potato salad. In some parts of Slovakia, so called “pupáčky” (or little sweet dumplings topped with poppy seeds and butter) are eaten as a starter or dessert. On the same day in Britain, children hang their **stockings at the foot of their beds** or by the fireplace for Father Christmas to fill them. In the USA, children expect Santa Claus to come down the **chimney**. On the morning of *Christmas Day*, December 25th, children get up early to open their Christmas presents. During the meal, they open their **Christmas crackers** which usually make a banging noise and contain some small toy, a coloured paper crown, a motto or a joke. For Christmas dinner, British families have **stuffed turkey, roast or mashed potatoes** and **Christmas pudding** afterwards. It is made of dried fruit and is served flambé. Christmas pudding contains a ring (it means you will get married that year), a coin (you will be wealthy) and a **thimble** (you will find work). In Britain and the USA, the following day is *Boxing Day* (December 26th) when many people visit other members of their families. In the past on that day, **servants** and salespeople got presents, usually money, from the **gentry**. These presents became known as Christmas boxes (servants and salespeople carried boxes to get tips). In Slovakia, people also visit their families on this day.

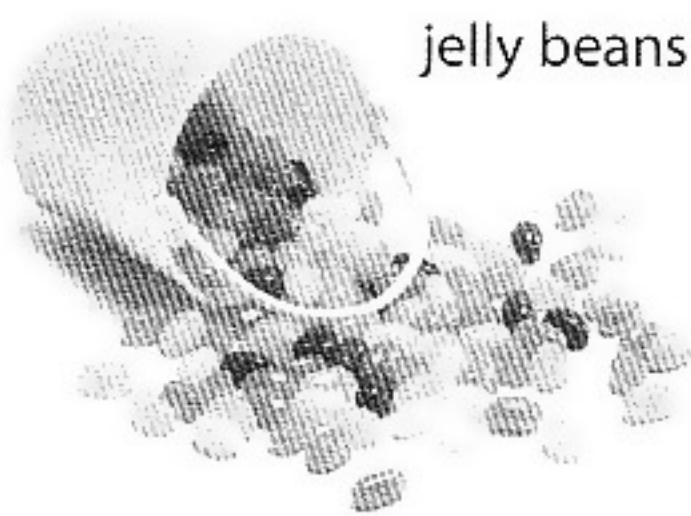
In Slovakia, the period between *Epiphany* (January 6th) and *Ash Wednesday* is known as “*Fašiangy*” (*Shrovetide*) which is the equivalent to Carnival in some countries. At midnight before Ash Wednesday, the symbolic **burial** ceremony of the contrabass is performed. “*Fánky*” and “*šišky*” are traditionally eaten during the “*Fašiangy*”. In Britain, on *Shrove Tuesday* (which is known as *Pancake Day* or *Fat Tuesday*), people make pancakes to empty their cupboards before **Lent** starts.

1. When exactly is Christmas Eve and Christmas Day? What do the British/Americans do on these days? What do you know about Boxing Day?
2. During which holiday do British people eat pancakes? Why?

EASTER

Easter is celebrated over several days. *Ash Wednesday* is the first day of Lent which lasts forty-six days. Christians pray, attend **mass** and church services, go to **confession** and fast. They give up their **sinful** attitudes and non-fasting foods. *Good Friday*, the Friday before Easter, marks the anniversary of Christ’s **crucifixion**. *Easter Sunday* is the main religious feast celebrating when Jesus Christ was **resurrected** from the dead on the third day after the crucifixion. *Whit Monday*, seven weeks after Easter, is a Christian festival celebrated **in commemoration of** the coming of the **Holy Ghost**.

In the United States, children like Easter very much because the Easter Bunny comes with coloured chocolate eggs and other **confectionery**, such as marshmallow bunnies and **jelly beans**. Families often paint eggs and decorate Easter trees with them. On Good Friday, British people eat **hot cross buns** made with **currants** and **raisins** marked with a cross on the top to symbolise crucifixion. On Saturday, they sometimes decorate Easter eggs and hide them in their houses and gardens for children to hunt for on Easter Sunday. However, there



is nothing like the Easter Monday traditions that exist in Slovakia with water and **willow whips**. In Slovakia, Easter traditions are different in every region. In some places, gangs of boys go from house to house and look for young girls. According to tradition, they pour a **bucket** of water on them or sometimes even “wash” them in the nearest **spring**. Boys also whip girls with a willow whip called “*korbáč*” in Slovak. Afterwards, they are invited into the house by young girls’ parents and offered some food (**smoked** ham is very common) and some alcohol. Then they are given chocolate eggs, or decorated hand-made eggs called “*kraslice*” and sometimes money too.



hot cross buns

Many other religious holidays are also celebrated in Britain and America, as both countries have immigrants from many other cultures. The **best-known** of these are *Hanukkah* (the Jewish festival of lights held in December), the *Chinese New Year* (at the end of January or the beginning of February) and *Eid al-Fitr* (a Muslim celebration at the end of Ramadan, which is a period of fasting).

3. How do Easter traditions in Slovakia and Britain/the USA differ?
4. What other religious (non-Christian) holidays are mentioned in the text above?

SAINTS' HOLIDAYS

In Britain, there also exist holidays named after the **saints** such as *St. Patrick's Day*, *St. Andrew's Day*, *St. David's Day* and *St. George's Day*. The most famous is the national holiday of the Irish people *St. Patrick's Day* (March 17th), named after St. Patrick, the **patron saint** of Ireland, who brought **Christianity** to Ireland. Many people **worldwide** dress in green, eat Irish food and drink Guinness. St. Patrick's Day **parades** are held in many towns and cities in Ireland and the USA. February 14th is *St. Valentine's Day* when friends and lovers send one another letters or greeting cards expressing their love and affection. *Saint Valentine* was a **bishop**, a Christian **martyr**, **murdered** by the **Romans** around the year 273. Before he was put to death, he sent a note of friendship to his **jailer's** daughter. This holiday has been imported to our country and every year is becoming more and more popular. There is a wide choice of Valentine cards available at stationer's shops. The feast of *All Saints' Day* in our country is more or less connected with going to **cemeteries** and decorating **graves** with beautiful flowers and lit candles. The day of the patron saints of Slovakia, *Cyril and Methodius* (July 5th), is nationally celebrated all over the country **accompanied** by a variety of cultural events.

5. Which holidays named after the saints are celebrated in Britain?
6. What have you learnt about the origin of St. Valentine's Day?

PATRIOTIC HOLIDAYS

Guy Fawkes Night (November 5th) **has** its **roots** in English history. It goes back to the year 1605 when a group of Catholics wanted to kill *King James I* at the opening of Parliament by **blowing up** the Houses of Parliament with **gunpowder**. One of them, *Guy Fawkes*, was

caught **planting the explosives** and they were all **executed**. To commemorate the event, there are **bonfires** and **fireworks** in almost every town and village in Britain. Children are allowed to stay up until dark and admire the **rockets** in the sky. *Remembrance Sunday* (celebrated on the second Sunday in November) **commemorates** the contribution of people from the UK and the Commonwealth (military and civilian) to both wars and later conflicts as well as all victims of war.

One of the most important public holidays in the USA is the *Fourth of July* or *Independence Day*. It celebrates the independence of American colonies from the British. It is the **anniversary** of the signing of the *Declaration of Independence* in 1776. The oldest American holiday is *Thanksgiving Day* which is the fourth Thursday in November. It was celebrated for the first time in 1621 as an **expression** of the people's joy after the first successful **harvest** which helped the colony at Plymouth to **survive** the winter. *Memorial Day*, celebrated on May 30th in most states and *Veteran's Day* are patriotic holidays which commemorate Americans who fought in wars for their country. On these days, the people visit cemeteries and **memorials** to honour those who **sacrificed** their lives for America. The birthdays of two great American presidents, *Abraham Lincoln* and *George Washington*, are celebrated on February 17th, which is *President's Day*. Another of the most important events in American history was the discovery of the continent by *Christopher Columbus* on October 12th, 1492 which is celebrated with *Columbus Day*.

7. What have you learnt about patriotic holidays celebrated in Britain?

8. Why do Americans celebrate Thanksgiving Day?

OTHER HOLIDAYS

Halloween is a typical American holiday celebrated on October 31st. Its origins go back to the Celts who believed that on that day, the last day in their calendar, the spirits of the dead would come to their houses and would **take over** their bodies. Therefore, they **disguised** themselves with animal heads and skins to **cheat** or confuse the evil spirits to **discourage** them from visiting. They also lit huge bonfires, made lots of noise and played tricks on each other. Nowadays, children go from house to house knocking on doors saying "**trick or treat**". It means if you don't give them a treat, they will play a trick on you. It is popular with both young and old people who dress up in **fancy dress costumes** and go to parties to have fun.

New Year's Day (December 31st) is neither a public holiday in Slovakia nor in England. People go to work as usual. But on New Year's Eve most Slovak and English people stay up till midnight to welcome in the New Year. Many go to parties and balls. At midnight people drink champagne, **propose a toast** and wish each other Happy New Year. Beautiful fireworks and rockets light up the sky. In England, *New Year's Day* (January 1st) is a bank holiday. People make **resolutions** and promises to change or improve their future lives. In Slovakia, many people spend this time in the mountains with their friends and family.

9. According to the text, what is the origin of Halloween?

10. How do people celebrate New Year's Day in your country?

□ VOCABULARY LIST

to accompany – sprevádzať
anniversary – výročie
Ash Wednesday [æʃ] – Popolcová streda
bishop – biskup
to blow up – vyhodit' do povetria
bonfire – vatra
bucket [bʌkɪt] – vedro
burial [berɪəl] – pohrebný
carp – kapor
cemetery [semətri] – cintorín
to cheat – podvádzať
chimney [tʃɪmni] – komín
Christianity [krɪstɪ'ænəti] – kresťanstvo
Christmas carol – vianočná koleda
Christmas cracker – vianočné cukríky
Christmas market – vianočný trh
Christmas pudding [pʊdɪŋ] – puding
to commemorate – uctiť si pamiatku
confectionery [kən'fekʃənəri] – sladkosti
confession [kən'feʃn] – spoveď
crucifixion [kru:sə'fɪkʃn] – ukrižovanie Ježiša Krista
currant [kʌrənt] – ríbezľa
Declaration of Independence – Vyhlásenie nezávislosti
to discourage – odradiť
to disguise – zamaskovať sa
Easter – Veľká noc
Epiphany – sviatok Troch kráľov
to execute – popraviť
expression – vyjadrenie
fancy dress costume – maškarný kostým
to fast – postiť sa
fireworks – ohňostroj
gentry [dʒentri] – panstvo, zámožná vrstva
gingerbread – medovník
good act – dobrý skutok
Good Friday – Veľký piatok
grave – hrob
gunpowder – strelný prach
harvest – žatva
holly – cezmína
Holy Ghost – Duch Svätý
holly mass – svätá omša
hot cross buns – veľkonočné buchtičky
ivy [aɪvi] – brečtan
jailer [dʒeɪlə(r)] – žalárnik
jelly beans [dʒeli] – želé cukríky (fazuľky)

Lent – pôst
martyr [mɑ:tə(r)] – mučeník
mashed potatoes – zemiaková kaša
mass – omša
memorial – pomník
mistletoe [mɪsltəʊ] – imelo
mulled wine [mʌld waɪn] – varené víno
to murder – zavraždiť
New Year's Eve – Silvester
parade – sprievod
patron saint – svätý patrón, ochranca
raisin – hrozienko
to remain – zostať
resolution – predsavzatie
to resurrect [reza'rekt] – vstať z mŕtvych
roasted – opekaný
rocket – raketa (ohňostroj)
Romans – Rimania
to sacrifice [sækrɪfaɪs] – obetovať
saint – svätý
servant – sluha
sinful – hriešny
smoked – údený
spirits – liehoviny, duše zomrelých
spring – prameň
stocking – (vianočná) pančucha
stuffed turkey – plnený moriak
to survive – prežiť
to take over – prevziať kontrolu
thimble [θɪmbəl] – náprstok
trick or treat – fráza, ktorú hovoria deti na Halloween, keď chodia od domu k domu a čakajú nejakú odmenu. Ak ju nedostanú, niečo ľuďom vyvedú. («trik alebo odmena»)
to unwrap – rozbaľiť
to vary [veəri] – líšiť sa
wafer [weɪfə(r)] – oblátka
willow whip – korbáč z vrby
worldwide – na celom svete

at the foot of the bed – na konci postele (kde má ležiaci nohy)
in commemoration of – na pamiatku
to have roots in – mať korene v
to plant the explosives – položiť, umiestniť výbušniny
to propose a toast – predniesť prípitok

□ VOCABULARY PRACTICE

Task 1 Which holidays are described below? Choose the name from the box.

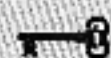


*Boxing Day – Christmas – Easter – St. Patrick's Day –
Independence Day – New Year's Eve – Thanksgiving Day – Valentine's Day*

- a) It is the day of all lovers and friends. They send cards to each other.
- b) In the USA, children like this holiday very much because they get many coloured chocolate eggs and candies. This holiday usually lasts a few days. In Slovakia, we have traditions with water and willow whips on the Monday.
- c) It is an American holiday which celebrates the independence of American colonies from the British. It is the anniversary of the signing of the Declaration of Independence in 1776.
- d) It is the oldest American holiday. It was first celebrated in 1621 after the first successful harvest which helped the colony at Plymouth to survive the winter.
- e) Long before this holiday, people decorate their homes and offices with coloured lights and trees. There are church services where people sing carols. People give presents to each other and spend more time together.
- f) It is an Irish holiday named after the patron saint who brought Christianity to Ireland. People dress in green and drink Guinness. There are parades in towns and cities in Ireland and the USA.
- g) It is the day after Christmas Day. On this day, people usually visit their families.
- h) It is the last day of the year and people normally go to work. They don't go to bed early but stay up till midnight to see the fireworks.

Task 2 Read the following dates out loud and correctly. Then, decide which holidays are celebrated in which English-speaking countries on these days.

Find the information in the previous text or look for it on the Internet.



Example: February 14th

St. Valentine's Day is celebrated on February the fourteenth (or on the fourteenth of February) in all English-speaking countries.

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| a) January 1 st _____ | e) December 24 th _____ |
| b) March 17 th _____ | f) December 25 th _____ |
| c) July 4 th _____ | g) December 26 th _____ |
| d) October 31 st _____ | h) December 31 st _____ |

□ REVIEW

Task 10 The words in each line are connected with some public holiday.
Name the holiday and underline the word which is the odd one out.

—8

Example:

hats – witches – pumpkin – church – skeleton – ghosts – costumes – “trick-or-treat”
HALLOWEEN

- a) resolutions – wishes – champagne – Christmas crackers – fireworks _____
- b) Bunny – grass – chocolate eggs – spring – turkey _____
- c) freedom from Britain – Declaration of Independence – Puritans – parades – patriotism – American flag _____
- d) Pilgrims – Mayflower – carol – hunger – successful harvest – turkey _____
- e) green – shamrock – Guinness – “pub crawling” – fasting _____
- f) presents – festive dinner – bonfires – Santa Claus – Rudolph (the Red Nosed Reindeer) – stockings _____

Task 11 Explain the meaning of the following traditional meals eaten in Slovakia on different holidays. What other traditional meals are eaten in your region and when? Talk about them.

- a) pupáčky
- b) šišky
- c) vianočné oplátky
- d) fánky
- e) vianočka
- f) štedrák
- g) makové šúľance
- h) huspenina